Schopenhauer

Arthur Schopenhauer is one of the most distinctive and influential German philosophers of the nineteenth century. That is remarkable because his work can be unpleasant, even repellent. He holds views calculated to make people uncomfortable and shake them out of their complacency. The bitterness and sharpness of his writing are unlike the prevailing optimism of many Romantic writers. Yet he writes with a liveliness that contrasts with the sombre and pessimistic content. Among German poet-philosophers, Nietzsche is a good comparison. Schopenhauer is worth reading in part because of his influence on Nietzsche, Freud and Wittgenstein.

With many philosophers, family background tells us little about the philosophy. Knowing how Kant lived, for example, does not tell us much about the *Ding an sich*, the thing in itself. Schopenhauer is different. His father died in what may have been a suicide. In my view, the loss helps explain the lasting negativity of Schopenhauer's outlook. His relationship with his mother was distant and eventually ended in estrangement. He was almost entirely alone in the social world. It is hard to imagine anyone dwelling on his unhappiness more than Schopenhauer, and he offers to share it with us. That willingness may be his one gentle gesture towards humanity. In this case it is difficult to separate the man from the philosophy. If philosophy is the right word for it, we might call it the metaphysics from hell.

Schopenhauer was an indefatigable reader. Among philosophers, Plato and Kant were his most important influences. Rather than reinvent the wheel, he accepts parts of Kant's account and then turns other parts upside down. Like other German thinkers of the early nineteenth century, he is steeped in Kant. At university he also heard Fichte and Schleiermacher. What distinguishes him is that he was among the early European intellectuals who read deeply in the religious thought of India, particularly the *Upanishads*. Buddhist ideas also help illuminate his work. Desire becomes a problem to be solved, and the individual personality an obstacle to be overcome rather than simply a limit to experience. In Schopenhauer this pessimistic reading of Hindu and Buddhist themes combines, oddly, with German idealism.

He is, in a sense, a one-trick pony, though extraordinarily good at his trick. He takes a philosopher, retains some elements and stands the rest on its head. The inversions are often disturbing and sometimes intriguing. His essays are his most accessible work, but they are difficult to recommend without qualification. The misogyny and racism can be repellent, and he makes no attempt to conceal them. If you want a way into Schopenhauer, start with the essays all the same. His one great philosophical work, *The World as Will and Representation*, also translated as *The World as Will and Idea*, can be intimidating.

Schopenhauer had a particular animus towards Hegel. They were at the University of Berlin at the same time, when Hegel was at the height of his career and one of the most celebrated intellectuals in the Western world. Schopenhauer deliberately scheduled his lectures against Hegel's. Hegel attracted hundreds, while Schopenhauer attracted a few and failed to build a following. As frustrated intellectuals often do, Schopenhauer took the lack of recognition to show that his audience had failed to recognise his superiority. One line has stayed with me since college: he apologises to the reader of the future for

mentioning Hegel, a philosopher that reader will never have heard of. It is a harsh thing to say, and conveys his attitude more vividly than a description could. As it happens, we have heard of Hegel.

The book first appeared at the end of 1818 with 1819 on its title page. Its construction is remarkably musical. Thomas Mann described its four parts as a symphony in four movements. Schopenhauer's aesthetic gifts bring out a disturbing fact about philosophical writing. Literary elegance and creativity are compatible with saying deeply unpleasant or offensive things. Nietzsche is another example. Schopenhauer's book can sound like verbal music, with a high poetic content, as long as one does not stop to think about what it is telling us.

The book takes up the distinction between subject and object and the Kantian distinction between noumena and phenomena. Schopenhauer keeps some Kantian elements and reverses others to make his own metaphysics. He begins by asking what it is like to be a self-conscious being in this world, a question with deep spiritual implications. The problem resembles Kierkegaard's, but Schopenhauer offers no solution to it. It is the human condition itself. Like Hamlet, he is trapped in an egoistic prison called the world. He seems to have discovered its perimeter and reports on what it is like. There is a negativity as relentless as Kierkegaard's, but here it is a kind of sinfulness without redemption.

The first part treats the world as representation. The German word *Vorstellung* is also the source of the older translation "idea". To understand the argument, we need to go back to Hume and Kant and ask how the mind works. For the British empiricists, think of the mind as a *tabula rasa*, a blank slate, or as an empty box. A baby begins to see, hear, touch and taste, and sensations enter the box. The mind gives coherence to the sensations by bundling them together. I can see that a lectern is hard, heavy, smooth and brown and gather those impressions into what I call the lectern.

Hume's difficulty is that we can see tables, chairs, people, floors and ceilings, but never see time, space or causality as such. If I let go of a pen, I see myself release it and see it fall. I can do this a hundred times with the same result. What I see is a regular succession. I do not see the necessity of the causal connection. Likewise, clocks and calendars give me mechanisms and pieces of paper, not time itself. What holds experience together in these cases cannot simply be another impression. Empiricism thus faces a problem in accounting for space, time, causality, being, negation and number. Kant takes up the challenge.

For Kant the mind does not passively absorb impressions. It actively shapes the world as we experience it. Imagine the mind as a room with one window and locked doors. You will never get out of the room. The world you see looks exactly as the window allows it to look, because it is your sole access to the outside. The light that enters is shaped by the opening. In much the same way, the mind imposes forms on external experience. This is a more adequate account of cognition than the picture of a blank slate or an empty box.

Consider the lectern again. I experience it as spatial and temporal. It is here at the beginning and, with any luck, at the end. It takes up a certain space, and if I walk into that space, I will hit it. Kant's account distinguishes space and time as forms of intuition and also identifies twelve categories of the understanding. These structures are a priori:

they are not acquired from experience, but help make it possible for us to experience the world as human subjects. They necessarily shape the way the external world appears to us.

There are lecterns, cups of coffee, sheets of paper, people and other objects in the world. Yet we never experience them without mediation. Space, time, causality, number, being and negation are involved in how we experience objects as subjects. T. S. Eliot captures something of this in the rose garden of the *Four Quartets*: “the roses / Had the look of flowers that are looked at.” The lectern likewise looks like a lectern that is looked at. We cannot find out what it is apart from the conditions under which we look at it. We all know what space or quantity is in practice, yet it is hard to explain either to someone who does not already understand it. Such forms are built into human cognition.

That is Schopenhauer’s foundation in the first movement. The whole phenomenal world is one vast representation, constituted by the subject’s activity. For Kant, the corollary is that we cannot know the *Ding an sich*. I cannot experience what the lectern is in itself, as it might appear to the mind of God independently of space, time, causality and number. I have to look through the window. I experience the world as a human being must experience it. There is no direct access to noumena, only to the phenomenal world shaped by the a priori forms.

In the second movement, Schopenhauer turns Kant’s position around. There is one case, he argues, in which we have access to what a thing is in itself: we know ourselves from within as willing beings. Our immediate awareness of willing gives us a kind of access we do not have to external objects. On this reading, the world outside is mediated as Kant says, whereas inwardly we encounter a single reality, will. The emphasis on will has important consequences for late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century thought. One can see how it might be transformed in Nietzsche into the will to power.

As Hobbes suggests, human beings are desiring animals. Schopenhauer adds that we do not really know our own wills. Consciousness and reason are only parts of will, and reason neither controls nor understands the force that governs it. A larger and more mysterious force is at work in us. This anticipates Freud’s conception of an unconscious dimension of our mental life. We lose the Enlightenment’s optimistic image of rational animals in command of their wills. The will is in command of us.

Will is one blind, purposeless force at work throughout nature, not simply in individual people. Compare it to Spinoza’s *conatus*, the tendency of each thing to persist in what it is. Schopenhauer can be read as turning this around: things strive to be otherwise, yet have no command over what they are and get along as best they can. We are playthings of something less than God, a force without a conscious design or any affection for us. We are froth on the ocean of reality.

This view is in a sense anti-Socratic. If we can know ourselves, we do so after the fact, learning what we really willed from what we actually did. Suppose I forget someone’s name. I later wish I had remembered it, but then realise that I did not like the person and did not want to speak to them. In that sense, I did not will to remember. This anticipates Freud’s account of parapraxis, the apparently accidental slip that reveals a motive.

Viewed from outside, the world is representation. Viewed from inside, it is will. What then are we, and how are we to live? Desire is a negative condition because it begins in privation. Here Schopenhauer's reading of Buddhism and Hinduism comes to the fore. We would be better off not existing, but because we do, we lurch from desire to desire without being in control. Satisfying hunger, sexual desire or the desire for love is like scratching an itch. It feels good to scratch, but it would be better not to itch in the first place. The relief is negative. From this perspective it would be better not to feel anything at all.

The Buddhist emphasis on suffering, illness and death, familiar from the Four Noble Truths, helps explain the affinity. In this reading of Schopenhauer, the longing for release and for nirvana is a longing to abolish the self, a longing brought close to death. It is hard to imagine a more relentless pessimism. We have a doubtful prospect of self-knowledge and a spiritual problem without spiritual redemption. The last two movements of the philosophical symphony nevertheless seek ways of responding. The third addresses the world as representation and the fourth the world as will.

How can we escape the prison of subjectivity imposed by the Kantian categories? How can we get beyond a life of contingency, a veil of *maya* or illusion, and a succession of desires we neither need nor satisfy? Schopenhauer offers two ways out. The first is aesthetics, perhaps his greatest and certainly one of his most influential contributions. Art offers a kind of redemption. Aesthetic apprehension is for him the purest objectivity human beings attain. There is some plausibility to that. When philosophers give up theology and a moral order in the world, they often turn to art for a substitute for transcendence.

The objectivity of aesthetic experience applies to the artist as well as to the spectator. Genius consists in the capacity for objective seeing. We recognise a great artist through works in which we can see that the artist apprehended the world as it really is. Moral and political philosophers may not be impressed, but the theory has mattered in aesthetics. This is the part most likely to appear in an excerpt. It gives art the highest cognitive rank, turning Plato's order upside down. What Plato's divided line puts at the bottom as an image or imitation becomes the highest activity, because for Schopenhauer it offers access to objectivity.

His view of tragedy likewise inverts Aristotle's *Poetics*. In the familiar Aristotelian account, a larger-than-life figure comes to disaster through an error or fatal flaw, and the tragedy produces catharsis. Hubris is one familiar example. For Schopenhauer the most revealing tragedy concerns an ordinary person who meets catastrophe through no fault of their own. This is supposed to enlighten us, but it is terrifying. Ordinary people meet terrible disasters without any reason. Suffering is open to all of us and cannot be avoided. A kind of anti-tragedy tells us what the world really is: chaotic, meaningless suffering.

This anticipates Kafka, who admired Schopenhauer. One day Gregor Samsa wakes to find himself transformed into a bug. He is an ordinary person and suffers for no reason anyone understands. The example shows how much of later German-language culture is foreshadowed here. Schopenhauer's views on music were also influential, especially for Wagner, although Schopenhauer disdained him. Remarkable gifts and a deeply difficult disposition can coexist.

For Schopenhauer music is a direct apprehension and expression of will, a copy of will itself. It requires no translation from one language to another. It communicates without depending on conventional symbols, speaking directly from one will to another. Here too he sees the highest kind of objectivity. One can see why Wagner was drawn to the idea. The other way out of the problem of the world as representation, besides aesthetics, is ethics.

It is surprising to find Schopenhauer writing about ethics. Here the way out of the prison of subjectivity is to break down the illusory boundaries of the ego. In the Buddhist and Christian traditions, the saint's loving kindness overflows the boundaries of the self. The saint recognises in another person's pain their own suffering. Universal compassion is the foundation of ethics in both traditions, on this account. The saint and the artist can both get outside the prison of subjectivity. Art communicates aesthetic objectivity, and charitable action manifests ethical objectivity by showing that the agent has gone beyond the bounds of the self. Escaping the self is what this philosophy is about. If you were Arthur Schopenhauer, you might want to escape from yourself too.

The final movement is perhaps the most intriguing and the most depressing. It asks how to get beyond will, beyond our understanding of ourselves from the inside. One might call it tough love, although it is hard to tell whether Schopenhauer is trying to do us a kindness. He seems to think that nihilism can be edifying. In a terrible world it might be good to know the worst. At least here is the worst, and one can try to do something with it.

Asceticism and mysticism are the two ways beyond will. We are a bundle of desires moving from one desire to the next. The way beyond desire follows the path of Christian and Buddhist mystics and saints. Denying the flesh, fasting, self-flagellation and withdrawing as a hermit or anchorite are examples of practices that deny the will. By facing down the will one seeks the detachment of the Buddhist or of the Christian saint who withdraws from society and repeatedly denies the will. This may give access to the best possible human life, if not to blessedness. It is a grim thought that asceticism should be the way out. Death, suffering and old age are unavoidable. It would be best not to be born. Who is so lucky? If we are born, the best we can do is to face down and control the will. Exercising a will to power over oneself points forward to Nietzsche.

Mysticism offers another way out by suspending rational thought and collapsing the distinction between will and representation. Asceticism and mysticism share a longing for the abolition of the self. It is a kind of worship of one's own extinction, an embrace of finitude because the particular time, place and experiences that make up one's finite life are so relentlessly awful. This brings back themes from the *Upanishads* and from Hindu and Buddhist thought. There is a difference, however: in traditions that assume rebirth, suicide offers no escape. I would describe the longing for extinction expressed here as a kind of philosophical suicide or an ode to death.

Schopenhauer draws two conclusions about the human condition. The first reverses Leibniz. Leibniz calls this the best of all possible worlds. Voltaire casts doubt on that claim, whereas Schopenhauer calls it the worst of all possible worlds. If it were any worse, it could not exist at all. It is just viable enough to exist. This proves nothing about the world. It reveals a state of mind, no more a logical demonstration than the claim that it is the best of all possible worlds.

The second conclusion is that it is better never to have been born. We are bundles of desires and collections of questions. Our desires are never finally satisfied, our questions never finally answered, and we are stuck with them. Schopenhauer wants to throw in the towel, to ask for release, but has no God to whom he can pray. Pleasure is negative: we begin with a lack, then enjoy perhaps fifteen minutes of satisfaction before the desire returns. He wants to eat lunch and never feel hungry again. Hunger inevitably comes back. That, he would say, is exactly the point. Why would we want a world like this? Two terrible things can happen: getting what we want and failing to get it. This is the metaphysics from hell.

No wonder he wants to get out of the prison of the ego. Asceticism and mysticism answer the problem of the self. Ethics and aesthetics answer the problem of subjectivity and of our relation to the external world. These are the highest human achievements, yet in this bleak account even they come to very little. Everything spirals down towards permanent despondency. Perhaps Schopenhauer's revenge on the world is to turn his unhappiness into a system of metaphysics and send it to us. It has been a revenge of great consequence for the intellectual history of the West.

By the late nineteenth century, educated German speakers would have known Schopenhauer. Freud, who grew up in Vienna, provides an example of his importance. Unconscious motivation, the idea that we are often unaware of what really moves us, is already present in Schopenhauer. Consciousness is a surface above depths we cannot sound. The Freudian slip reveals what we actually willed. Look back at what you did, he would say, and stop deceiving yourself. For Schopenhauer, the body and sexuality are central to desire, and he calls the genitals the focus of will. The later emphasis on irrational desire and motivation is anticipated here.

Another legacy is art as redemption, a path to a kind of secular blessedness. Nietzsche and the late nineteenth-century advocates of art for art's sake take up this theme. If the heaven of the Christian saints is closed, perhaps we can gain access to the earth of the pagan artists. Art becomes a kind of secular religion. One could see this as a philosophical expression of German Romanticism: Goethe over Luther, redemption through art, creativity or the contemplation of creativity.

The primacy of will over intellect is another lasting theme. Think of a rider on a horse. The horse is the will. It carries you about and makes the decisions, perhaps like an untamed horse for which you have no bridle. You go where it goes, though you like to believe you are leading it. Do not flatter yourself about your autonomy. This view leads towards forms of vitalism such as Bergson's and towards the voluntarism of Sorel and some later existentialists. Authentic commitment becomes important even without an ultimate rational ground. Commit yourself to something rather than standing still.

Schopenhauer has little sympathy for an optimistic Christianity promising salvation and reconciliation with God. For him the world is a vast emptiness. Nietzsche takes up this resistance, and his writing is suffused with Schopenhauer. He took him seriously as a moralist and, on first reading *The World as Will and Representation*, was so impressed that he read it again. Schopenhauer's greatest importance may lie in the influence he exerted over several generations of thinkers, who gave the themes their own turns.

Freud's *Civilization and Its Discontents* is pessimistic, though less relentlessly than Schopenhauer. Both see human life as full of desires that remain unsatisfied and cannot

all be satisfied. Freud is prepared to say that giving up civilisation would be worse. Nietzsche abandons much of the Enlightenment's rational optimism and transforms Schopenhauer's will into the will to power, a force at work not only in individuals but in nature and the world as a whole. This is one of Nietzsche's most important ideas.

Wittgenstein is a more surprising case. He read Schopenhauer closely without simply adopting his philosophical pessimism. His own periods of melancholy, or his upbringing in late nineteenth-century Vienna, may help explain the attraction. He takes up a mood of melancholy and the idea that in aesthetics and ethics we reach the boundaries of language. Trying to formulate them in words is like running up against a glass wall. What results may be mysticism or mere noise. At the end of the *Tractatus*, Wittgenstein says that we must pass over in silence what we cannot speak about. He seems to me to suggest that something is there, although we cannot speak of it. On my reading, Schopenhauer's more desolate answer is that nothing is there to be said. At the boundary we are left with symbols, gestures and noise.

Kant, Indian mysticism and Romantic *Weltschmerz* make a strange brew. Read in a Kierkegaardian way, this is an ode to boredom. The world is a vacuum, offering nothing but misery and negative experiences. It is a demonic inversion of pantheism: instead of a world filled with God, we have a world filled with nothing. The best we can do is face that nothing and our boredom, turn to aesthetic contemplation and renounce the self in asceticism or mysticism. The problem of the world remains insoluble, and the problem of the self has no solution. We are left in a spiritual tar pit from which we cannot pull ourselves. Before we succumb to death, Schopenhauer wants us to understand why he regards it as the best that can happen to us.